The earliest known examples of the Brahmi script are the words set down in stone by Chandragupta's grandson Ashoka Maurya from about 260 BCE onwards. This does not mean that Brahmi was not employed before then, only that there is no solid proof that it was.[1] That is the established view, although it is being challenged by recent claims that Brahmi lettering originated not in India's north-west but either in Lanka or in Tamil country, and as early as the fourth or even the fifth century BCE. These claims are based partly on ongoing excavations at the ancient Lankan capital of Anuradhapura but also on the discovery of hundreds of very short inscriptions on pots and sherds at an excavation site at Kodumanal, a small village on the north bank of an upper tributary of the Cauvery River in Tamil Nadu. This was once an important trading centre known as Kodumanan, sited on the ancient highway through the Palakkad Gap that linked the Cauvery delta and the Chera capital of Variti (modern Karur) with the great sea-port of Muciri, known to the Romans as Muziris.

This site had been either abandoned or destroyed by conquest in about the fifth century CE and subsequently forgotten, only to be rediscovered in 1983 by a young student named K. Rajan, now the respected Professor of History at Pondicherry University. In the course of research for his PhD on megalithic culture Rajan came across a site east of the village of Kodumanal dotted with cairn circles and menhirs (standing stones) which he recognised as a cist burial site, where the dead are placed within stone compartments. Seven seasons of excavations have since shown Kodumanan to have been a major centre for the early production of high-quality steel. But it also had a huge burial complex, only part of which has so far been uncovered. Many of the compartmented chambers contain grave goods in the form of pots, the earliest of which are inscribed with rudimentary symbols such as suns, swastikas, wheels and